

W3bster Says w00t!

From the online gamers' lingo, the word 'w00t'—an expression of joy—was crowned as Word of the Year 2007 by Merriam-Webster Inc. The entry in the dictionary will reflect thus, and is the first time I33t language has made it into the world of "propah" English.



Audiophiles Are Pirates

According to the Recording Industry Ass. Of America (RIAA), ripping personal CDs to the MP3 format on your PC is copyright infringement—even the possession of such copies could be unauthorised and illegal. This means audiophiles backing up the digital copies of their CDs are pirates. Play safe, now!



Escape

PAY TO GET SPAMMED

Exploring Charted Territory

You've won a lottery... Get a free iPhone... Resize your manhood... The bigger the better... You can easily recognise these as the subject lines of the delete-worthy mails in your Inbox. However, intriguing subject lines do entice a select few idiots into opening the mails—in case you didn't know.

Creating good spam filters to tackle such mails has been the agenda of many security companies, working with Web-based mail service providers. McAfee recently decided to think outside the box; the company said they would be hiring volunteers from the UK and the US for a thirty-day spam analysis. The research has been dubbed "Super Spam Me." The distasteful thing the volunteers would have to do is to reply to the spam messages; this act will supposedly help the

researchers figure how that will affect the flow of spam. The project, if one may call it that, will only include a few paid volunteers.

Here's the first bit of hilarity: applicants would have to send an e-mail to the company that oversees McAfee's PR work. Seeing as the job (namely, to reply to spam messages) is easy to perform, there will doubtless be thousands of volunteers (people tend to like money). The poor slob who will now receive more McAfee PR mails than other spam, we can bet.

In case you haven't figured it already, the second point here is that everyone knows what's going to happen. When you respond to a spam mail, you're going to get more spam—for those not in the know, this is because the spammer gets to know that yours is a valid, active e-mail address. So

what's with the bit about analysing how the flow of spam would be affected? If you can guess, if we can guess, McAfee can guess, too—more spam, period.

The deal, evidently, is this: get paid to get more spam—from your spammers as well as from us. Quite normal for a regular Web company to be offering something like this—but not quite normal for a company that should be spending its time making spam filters.

PRIVACY WOES

No more Pokey-Pokey!

Whether it is to spy on a cheating husband or to probe into a murder, social networking sites have become a major source of

Whatever Happened To...

The Semantic Web

The Semantic Web is an idea that promises to make Net-connected computers understand human language. When we search for information on the Net or files on a computer, we enter a specific set of keywords; with the Semantic Web, if you enter a search query saying that you want to book flight tickets for Mumbai to Bangalore at the lowest possible fares for the last flight on Sunday, the computer will automatically sift through all the data and present to you the best result—essentially, better data retrieval and more accurate results.

According to Tim Berners-Lee—the inventor of the Web—and his colleagues at the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C), the Semantic Web will make use of detailed metadata present in documents to identify and tag each and every file on a network. This tag will then work with other technologies to further categorise the document and its contents.

The idea seems brilliant, but there are problems galore. It is practically impossible for the entire Web to be made semantic, because the documents on the network today do not contain detailed metadata, and modifying them in the future is an insanely formidable task. But when you consider that Berners-Lee has been actively working on this for the past decade, you start to wonder what's been happening to it!

Win!

My Desktop

Lakhya Jyoti Nath, Sonitpur, Assam

How he did it:

It's confusing—is he running Windows? Is he running Linux? Both? What Lakhya's done here is a variation of an old trick—customised his Windows XP desktop to his liking and taken a screenshot on it. He then fired up SLAX from our December 2006 CD and applied the XP desktop as a wallpaper! So simple, yet so befuddling.

Participate in this contest and win next month

.net Interview Questions

by Nagaraju B

Published by

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Send us your desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.

DigiPick
of the month

Please open the door to your Windows



Last month's winner:

Benoy Somanathan
Chennai

Participate and
win next month:

Beginning
Access 2007 VBA

by Denise Gosnell

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier.

E-mail your picture with "DigiPick" in the subject line, mentioning your postal address, on or before the 20th of this month to digipick@thinkdigit.com. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

investigation leads. In the recent past, even news dailies have started looking in on online social communities for people involved in various crimes.

Mark Zuckerberg, Facebook founder, had a heart attack (14 December 2007) when he learnt that his personal documents and information were floating online for free download. (Actually, we're just speculating—about the heart attack and the date, that is.) His application to Harvard University—which carried his social security number, the New York address of his parent's house, and also his girlfriend's full name, was available to anyone with an Internet connection.

What happened was that a freelance reporter, in an independent magazine called 01238 (yes, that's what it's called) wrote a story "poking" a conversation about the suit filed by ConnectU.com on Facebook for stealing their idea. (Yes, we know it's complex, and we'll leave out further details because (a) You might not understand them, (b)

They're not interesting, and (c) We don't understand them ourselves.) At the end of the article were documents like Zuckerberg's correspondence with Harvard, Facebook's cash-flow statement for 2005, etc.

Find out more at <http://tinyurl.com/2w9w9p> (don't blame us if the article's been removed). The original documents that carry Zuckerberg's details have, naturally, already been removed. As it stands now, The Magazine Whose Name Contains No Words might face serious legal action...

But do you care? (We don't). The point is, when the owner of a social networking site cannot prevent his privacy (and a lot of it) being violated online, how can users be comfortable with putting up personal information on social networking sites?

Possible morals of the story: (a) Never trust anyone on the Internet. (b) Magazines with no letters in their names can sometimes be really stupid. (c) Reaffirm your belief in Scott McNealy's wisdom ("You've got zero privacy anyway...")

EGO-SURFING

Where Do I Stand, Virtually?

Google's search function has all but crippled humans. From recipes to research, people have stopped thinking; they Google stuff. (It might well be eventually proved that the average human neuron has shrunk in length by 40 per cent, that its shape has changed to vaguely resemble a "G", etc.) Very helpfully, all those billions of searches don't vanish into the digital void: Google's Zeitgeist comes out with statistics about the most searched-for terms. At the end of each year, we get a clear picture of what the year was like in terms of search (and therefore popular culture). The 2007 year-end Zeitgeist says the most popular search terms were iPhone, Transformers, Heroes, Facebook, and Anna Nicole Smith. (Most of which are guessable.)

People Who Changed Computing

The Communicator

You don't gawk at people around you when they use their mobiles, but it was a novel experience for New Yorkers when they saw Martin Cooper talking on a phone while walking along the street on 3 April 1973. At the time, he was head of R&D at Motorola; he made the first cell phone call to Joel Engel, his counterpart at competitor Bell Labs, on that



Martin Cooper

definitive April day. The mobile that Cooper used was a clumsy affair, though, a big as a brick and weighing almost a kilogram.

Portable phones were not new; there were already car phones, using which one could place a call from inside a car. But the concept of a portable phone was novel. An avid Star Trek fan, Cooper says he dreamed up the idea when he saw a character talking on a wireless communicator. And we call TV the Idiot Box...

Cooper is also known for Cooper's Law, which states that the number of conversations that can be carried out in a particular slice of the radio spectrum doubles every 30 months. An electrical engineer by training, he began his career with the US Navy and later joined Motorola in 1954. Cooper won the 2003 Wharton Infosys Business Transformation Award for his contributions to telecommunications.